



An engraving in the Italian newspaper *La Domenica del Corriere*, from February 1908, depicts the assassination of Charles I, king of Portugal. He was murdered during a period of increased calls for a republican government.

PORTUGAL WAS CONVULSED BY REVOLUTION following the assassination of its king, **Charles I** (1863–1908), in February. Already a highly unpopular monarch, he made matters worse by deciding to appoint his own prime minister—**bypassing parliament** in the process. Events took a violent turn on February 1 when Charles and his eldest son, Luís Filipe, were shot while they were traveling in a carriage in Lisbon. Charles was succeeded by his son, **Manuel II** (1889–1932), who managed to survive on the throne for just a couple of years before being overthrown (see 1910). In Africa, the **Congo Free State** (see 1884) was abolished and Belgium's government established the **Belgian Congo**. The Free State had been run by a private company with Belgian **King Leopold II** (1835–1909) ruling over it personally. Africans working in the Free State provided the company with valuable **rubber and ivory**. However, reports of the appalling labor conditions led to an **international**

KEY

- The Kingdom of Hungary
- The Austrian Empire
- Bosnia–Herzegovina
- Border of Austria–Hungary

The Austro–Hungarian Empire

In 1908, Austria–Hungary was eager to assert its control over the Balkan states of Bosnia and Herzegovina in order to prevent the Ottoman Empire from taking the territory.

outcry and calls for reforms. Belgium's answer to these demands was to make the territory an **official colony** and rule it from Brussels, ensuring the continued supply of Congolese products. But the brutal conditions persisted, and the **population dropped** from an estimated 20–30 million in 1884 to around 8.5 million by 1911.

Meanwhile, **Austria–Hungary** also reconfigured its colonial relationships—in its case with **Bosnia–Herzegovina**, which it had already occupied (see 1878). It had become worried about the implications of the **Young Turk Revolution** underway in the neighboring Ottoman Empire (see 1909). Austria–Hungary was concerned that its power in the Balkans might be undermined because, technically, Bosnia–Herzegovina was still under

Ottoman suzerainty and one of the Young Turks' aims was to reclaim the territory. After securing **Russia's** support, Austria–Hungary **annexed Bosnia–Herzegovina**. This move immediately angered nearby **Serbia**, which called for a section of Bosnia–Herzegovina that would give it access to the Adriatic Sea. Russia was soon caught in the middle of what would later be known as the **Bosnian Crisis**. At first it sought to secure some concessions for Serbia, but it later bowed to the demands of Austria–Hungary and its allies. During this period, **Bulgaria's Prince Ferdinand** (see 1887)—whose role as leader was not yet recognized by Russia and many other European countries—took advantage of the crisis to proclaim **Bulgarian independence** from the faltering Ottoman empire.



“ONE DAY MY **MORTAL BODY** WILL TURN TO DUST, BUT THE **TURKISH REPUBLIC** WILL STAND FOREVER.”

Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, first president of Turkey, 1926



Sultan Mehmed V

The 35th Ottoman sultan, Mehmed V (1844–1918), was effectively a puppet for the Young Turks' Committee of Union and Progress.

FOLLOWING THE SUCCESSFUL REBELLION BY THE YOUNG TURKS

the previous year, in 1909 the **Committee of Union and Progress**—the group's political wing—had taken control of the levers of power within the **Ottoman Empire**—something they would maintain for the next couple of years, despite internal disputes. The Young Turks had wanted to force the sultan to **restore the constitution**, and once this was accomplished Abdul Hamid II (r. 1876–1909) ruled as a constitutional monarch, although only briefly—he was deposed on April 27. They then proceeded to make his brother, **Mehmed V** (r. 1909–1918), the new sultan.

Many of the Young Turks had been students and members of the Ottoman intelligentsia and they organized themselves while living in Europe and British-

controlled Egypt. Although they were initially seen as “liberal,” many of their policies were considered repressive, especially elsewhere in the empire. Much of the anger lay in the Young Turks' **nationalism**, which meant they wanted to push a **Turkish identity** at the expense of the many large ethnic groups throughout the Ottoman world, such as the Arabs and Slavs. However, they did implement some **progressive reforms**, such as secularizing the legal system and improving education, including allowing women better access to schooling. They also wanted to limit the amount of **foreign influence** throughout the empire in areas such as Bosnia–Herzegovina (see 1908).



MUSTAFA KEMEL ATATÜRK (1881–1938)

Having been involved with the Young Turk Revolution of 1908, Mustafa Atatürk led the Turkish national movement in the Turkish War of Independence. When the Republic of Turkey was established in 1923 he became its first president.

May 26 First major commercial oil discovery in Middle East is made at Masjid-al-Salam in southwest Persia

August 8 Wilbur Wright (1867–1912) makes first controlled powered flight

September 27 Henry Ford produces first Model T car

December 17 Abdul Hamid II (1844–1918) dissolves Turkish parliament

January 5 Colombia recognizes the independence of Panama

March 10 Anglo-Siamese Treaty signed in Bangkok

April 19 Anglo-Persian Oil Company (later BP) founded in Iran

July 25 French aviator Louis Blériot (1872–1936) flies across English Channel

November 18 Nicaraguan president José Santos Zelaya (1853–1919) orders execution of 500 revolutionaries